



NayaHR — Subscriptions & Client Onboarding Guide

A practical runbook for taking NayaHR from "live demo" to "paying clients." Two parts: 1. **When do the free tiers run out** — what to buy, and when. 2. **How to onboard a client** — step by step.

Last updated: July 2026. Vendor pricing changes — re-check the linked pages before deciding.

PART 1 — Subscriptions: when do you need to pay?

You're on the free tiers of **Vercel**, **Clerk**, and **Neon**. Here's the honest trigger for each, in the order you'll actually hit them.

TL;DR — the order you'll upgrade

#	Service	Free is fine until...	What to buy	Cost	Trigger type
1	Vercel	you have any paying client	Pro	\$20/user/mo	Licensing (Terms of Service)
2	Neon	your first client with daily real usage	Launch (usage-based)	~\$5–25/mo at small scale	Reliability + compute limit
3	Clerk	~ 50,000 monthly active users, OR you want to remove "Secured by Clerk"	Pro	\$25/mo	Branding / scale
—	Anthropic (AI)	— (pay per use from day 1)	already pay-as-you-go	per token	Usage cost
—	Email (hello@nayahr.in)	you need a real support inbox	Zoho Mail / Google Workspace	~₹75–150/user/mo	Professionalism

1. Vercel — buy Pro the moment you take a paying client (first upgrade)

- The **Hobby (free) plan is non-commercial only**. Vercel's terms prohibit using it for a business. So the trigger is **legal, not technical**: the day you have a paying customer, you should be on **Pro (\$20/user/mo)**.
- Pro also gives commercial-use rights, **1 TB bandwidth**, higher limits, and \$20 of included usage credits.
- **One Pro plan covers both your Vercel projects** (marketing + app) — it's billed per team member, not per project.
- **Action**: upgrade to Pro before/at your first signed client.

2. Neon — move to Launch at your first real client (second upgrade)

- **Free plan:** 100 compute-hours/month, **0.5 GB storage**, scale-to-zero (the DB "sleeps" when idle).
- Two things will push you off free with real clients:
- **Compute (100 CU-hrs/mo):** a database serving clients throughout the day burns this quickly. Once you have steady daily usage you'll exceed it.
- **Cold starts:** on free, the sleeping DB takes ~0.5s to wake on the first request — a small but real UX hit for a live product.
- **Launch plan** is now **pure usage-based with no monthly minimum** (~\$0.11/compute-hour, \$0.35/GB-month). At small scale that's often **just a few dollars a month**, and you get: no cold-start pain, more compute headroom, and **longer backups / point-in-time recovery** — which you genuinely want for client **payroll** data.
- **⚠ Storage note specific to NayaHR:** profile photos and company logos are stored **inside** the database (as data URLs), and the `audit_log` grows forever. That eats the 0.5 GB faster than plain text would. Another reason to move off free early.
- **Action:** move to Launch before you depend on it for a real client's data (it's cheap at low usage, so err early).

3. Clerk — stay free a long time; Pro is mostly cosmetic

- **Free covers up to ~50,000 monthly active users** (raised in Feb 2026). Across many client companies that's still a long way off — e.g. 100 clients × 100 employees = 10,000, well under the cap.
- The **only near-term reason to pay \$25/mo (Pro)** is to remove the small **"Secured by Clerk"** footer on the sign-in screen for a cleaner, white-labelled look — nice for enterprise-y demos, not required.
- Your custom domain **clerk.nayahr.in** works on free. (Only extra *satellite* domains cost \$10/mo each — you don't need those.)
- **Action:** none required to onboard first clients. Consider Pro when you want to drop the Clerk branding.

4. Anthropic (the AI assistant) — a usage cost from day one

- Not a subscription — you **pay per token** each time someone uses the AI assistant. It's small per action but scales with usage.
- Keep an eye on it as clients adopt the assistant; set a monthly budget/alert in the Anthropic console.

5. Data residency (important for Indian clients / DPDP)

- Some Indian clients (especially larger ones) will ask **where their HR/payroll data is stored**. Neon runs on AWS regions including **Mumbai (ap-south-1)**.
- **Decide your production DB region deliberately** — moving regions later is disruptive. If Indian data residency matters to your buyers, host the production database in **Mumbai**. *(Check which region your current prod DB is in and plan accordingly before scaling.)*

Rough monthly floor once you have paying clients

Vercel Pro \$20 + Neon Launch ~\$5–15 + (optional Clerk Pro \$25) + Anthropic usage + email ~₹150.
Call it **~\$25–70/month** to run the whole platform for your first clients — margins stay healthy.

PART 2 — How to onboard a client (step by step)

This is the operational checklist for taking a signed client from "yes" to "live and trained."

Stage 0 — Before you touch the app (sales → kickoff)

Collect from the client (send them this list):

- [] **Legal company name** (as it should appear on payslips)
- [] **The Owner** — who will be the account owner (usually the founder or HR head): their **name + email**
- [] **HR admin(s)** who'll run the system day-to-day: names + emails
- [] **Employee roster** as a spreadsheet (see the exact format below)
- [] **Leave policy** — annual entitlements (Earned/Casual/Sick etc.)
- [] **Pay details** — monthly pay date, and whether they want NayaHR's default salary structure (Basic 40% / HRA / etc.)
- [] **Company logo** (PNG/JPG)

Set expectations (say this out loud): - NayaHR **calculates** payroll and produces payslips; **disbursement (bank transfer) and statutory filing (PF/ESI/PT/TDS) are done by them** in their bank/EPFO/TRACES portals, using NayaHR's numbers. (*This is the v1 boundary.*) - TDS shown is an **estimate** (new regime), not a declaration-based final figure.

Stage 1 — Provision the client's workspace (create their tenant)

NayaHR is **invite-only** (Clerk restricted mode + app-level gate), so a new company must be created deliberately. **Today's method:**

1. **Allow the Owner's email to create a company:** in **Vercel** → the **platform project** → **Settings** → **Environment Variables**, add/append their email (or domain) to **SIGNUP_ALLOWLIST** (comma-separated), then **redeploy**.
2. **Invite the Owner in Clerk:** Clerk Dashboard → (production instance) → **Users** → **Invitations** → **Invite** → their email. (*Restricted mode means they can't sign up without this.*)
3. **Owner accepts the email** → **signs up** at **app.nayahr.in**. Because their email is allowlisted and has no existing company, the app **creates a fresh tenant and makes them the Owner**.
4. **Clean up:** remove their email from **SIGNUP_ALLOWLIST** and redeploy (keeps the door closed).

 **Recommended improvement:** this 4-step dance doesn't scale past a handful of clients. A small **"Create client workspace" admin script/page** (pre-creates the tenant + owner invite in one action, no env edits) would make onboarding one click. *Worth building before you do this more than a few times — see "Gaps to close" below.*

Stage 2 — Owner sets up the company

Have the Owner (or do it with them on a screen-share):

1. **Rename the company:** sidebar → **Administrators** → **Company** → enter the legal name → Save. (*Fixes the default "My Company".*)
2. **Upload the logo:** sidebar company brand → **+ Logo**.
3. **Import the roster:** **People** → **Import** and upload the CSV (format below). This creates every employee with a dated Hire, their salary, and auto-creates departments/locations.

4. **Set managers:** open each employee (or the key ones) → edit job → set their **Manager**. (*The importer doesn't set reporting lines.*)
5. **Add HR admins: Administrators** → **Grant admin access** → pick the client's HR person(s) so they can run things too. (*They must be invited employees first — see Stage 3.*)

The exact roster CSV format

First row is the header. **Only name is required.** One employee per row.

```
name,title,department,location,salary,hire date,email
Rohan Mehta,Head of Engineering,Engineering,Bengaluru,3600000,10/02/21,rohan.mehta@acme.com
Priya Nair,Product Designer,Design,Bengaluru,1650000,05/07/22,priya.nair@acme.com
```

- **salary** = annual CTC as a plain number (no ₹, no commas): `1200000`.
- **hire date** = `DD/MM/YY`.
- Accepted header aliases: `title ↔ designation / role`, `department ↔ dept`, `location ↔ city`, `salary ↔ ctc / annual salary`, `hire date ↔ doj / date of joining`, `email ↔ email id`.
- **⚠ No commas inside any value** (the importer does a simple comma split) — e.g. write `Bengaluru`, not `Bengaluru, KA`.

⚠ Known limitation to fix before real imports: the importer currently stamps **today's date** as the hire date regardless of the CSV value — so tenure will be wrong for existing staff. **Flag this and fix the date parsing before onboarding a client with historical hire dates.** (*See "Gaps to close."*)

Stage 3 — Configure HR settings

1. **Leave:** the Indian leave types are built in (Earned, Casual, Sick, Maternity, Paternity, Bereavement, Marriage, Comp-off, Loss of Pay). Confirm the entitlements match the client's policy.
2. **Departments / locations:** created automatically from the roster — check they're clean (no duplicates from typos).
3. **Salary structure:** NayaHR splits CTC into Basic/HRA/Conveyance/Special automatically. Confirm the client is OK with the default split.

Stage 4 — Roll out to employees

1. **Invite employees: People** → **Invite** on each person (or the batch you want live). Each gets a **Clerk invitation email** and, on sign-up, lands in **self-service** (their profile, payslips, leave, goals). - If someone loses the email, use **Resend** next to their "Invited" status.
2. **Tell employees what to expect:** a short note from the client's HR — "You'll get an invite from NayaHR; sign in with your work email to see your payslips and apply for leave."

Stage 5 — First payroll (the proof moment)

1. Check every active employee has a **salary** and correct **Active** status.
2. **Payroll** → **Run payroll** → pick the month → **Generate draft**.
3. **Review** the per-employee table (Gross, PF, ESI, PT, TDS, Net).
4. **Finalize** — this locks the payslips and makes them visible to employees.

5. **The client then** transfers net pay via their bank and remits PF/ESI/PT/TDS by the due dates, using the run's totals.

Stage 6 — Train the client's HR admin

Walk their HR person through (use the **NayaHR-Overview** deck as a backdrop):

- **People** — add/edit employees, effective-dated changes, the Inbox for approvals
- **Recruitment** — requisitions → candidates → make offer (salary) → hire into Core HR
- **Time off** — approving leave, balances, Loss of Pay
- **Payroll** — the run → finalize → payslips
- **Performance** — goals & review cycle
- **Compensation** — salary changes with approval + history
- **AI assistant** — "ask it to do things" (and that it respects their role)
- **Administrators** — managing HR admins, transferring ownership, renaming company

Leave them with: the **Overview PDF**, your **support contact**, and the note that **finalized payroll is locked** (review before finalizing).

Stage 7 — Go-live & support

- [] Confirm the Owner + HR can log in and see the right data
- [] Confirm a test employee can see their payslip after finalize
- [] Share a **support channel** (email/WhatsApp) and response expectations
- [] Diarise a **check-in** after their first real payroll run

Onboarding checklist (one-glance)

- [] Collected: company name, owner email, HR emails, roster CSV, leave policy, logo
 - [] Vercel Pro active (if this is a paying client)
 - [] Neon on Launch (before real data)
 - [] Owner email added to SIGNUP_ALLOWLIST + redeployed
 - [] Owner invited in Clerk → signed up → tenant created
 - [] Removed owner email from SIGNUP_ALLOWLIST + redeployed
 - [] Company renamed + logo uploaded
 - [] Roster imported + departments/locations verified
 - [] Managers set + HR admins granted
 - [] Leave entitlements confirmed
 - [] Employees invited
 - [] First payroll run + finalized + payslip verified
 - [] HR admin trained + Overview deck shared
 - [] Support channel shared + check-in booked
-

Gaps to close before onboarding at scale (engineering to-do)

These are worth fixing/building so onboarding is smooth and repeatable:

1. **One-click client provisioning** — a small admin script/page that creates a tenant + owner invite in one step (removes the `SIGNUP_ALLOWLIST` + manual Clerk-invite dance).
2. **Fix roster hire-date import** — currently imports as *today*; parse the CSV `DD/MM/YY` so tenure/history is correct.
3. **CSV robustness** — support quoted fields so values can contain commas.
4. **Bank export + statutory summary** — the payday deliverables (NEFT/CSV of net pay; PF/ESI/PT/TDS totals sheet).
5. **Real support email** — `hello@nayahr.in` inbox (Zoho/Google Workspace).
6. **Data-residency decision** — confirm/host the prod DB in the Mumbai region for Indian clients.

Sources (pricing, as of July 2026)

- Vercel: <https://vercel.com/pricing>
- Clerk: <https://clerk.com/pricing>
- Neon: <https://neon.com/pricing>